

BEFORE

Small Neolithic villages on Crete gave way to large Minoan settlements, as Crete led Europe into the early Bronze Age.

NEOLITHIC SOCIETY

Dating back to c. 6500 BCE, the Neolithic people of Crete probably **originated in Asia Minor**. Their simple life centered around rearing livestock, growing crops, and making basic pottery.

EARLY BRONZE AGE

The earliest evidence of the Minoan civilization is c. 3000 BCE. During the 3rd millennium BCE, **trading towns** on the Cretan coast **expanded**. Early trading partners included the people of the **Cyclades** (islands north of Crete in the south-western Aegean), whose culture emerged at the same time. On the mainland, too, **Europe was entering the Bronze Age**, with bronze reaching most regions in the 2000s BCE. Bronze ax heads were common and were invested with religious significance in addition to practical uses.



EARLY CYCLADIC FIGURINE



BULGARIAN BRONZE AGE AX HEAD

INVENTION

THE FIRST MOVABLE TYPE?

The Phaistos Disk is an archaeological mystery. Made of clay, both sides of the disk feature symbols arranged in a spiral, and each symbol has been pressed into the clay with a punch. The script is unique and has not yet been deciphered. Discovered in the early 1900s during excavations of the palace at Phaistos on Crete, it has been dated to the period 1850–1350 BCE. Its meaning and usage is not fully understood but, as it features reusable stamps, some archaeologists believe it to be the earliest form of movable printing type, predating anything comparable by 2,000 years.



PHAISTOS DISK



Europe's First Civilization

The first civilization to make its mark in western Europe was the Bronze Age culture of the Minoans, based on the Mediterranean island of Crete. Frescoes in the grand palaces depict a highly sophisticated way of life, and hint at a society where women played an unusually dominant role for the times.

Archaeologists named the ancient Cretan civilization “Minoan” after Minos, a mythical king of Crete (see pp.102–03). The Minoan civilization flourished between c. 3000–1400 BCE, peaking around 1600 BCE, during the late Bronze Age (see p.43). It is famous for its extensive trading links across the sea, well-planned cities, beautiful palaces and artifacts, goddess worship, and a tradition of “bull-leaping” (see right).

Intriguingly, however, what we know of Minoan culture is scant and based purely on their ruins as experts are unable to fully decode their writing, known simply as “Linear A.” The Mycenaeans (see AFTER) modified Linear A to write the early form of Greek that they spoke. But while this Mycenaean script has been decoded using knowledge of Greek, the Minoans unknown, pre-Greek language still remains a mystery, and most of what they wrote down appears to be economic records.

Seafaring traders

An island location meant limited resources, so trade was crucial. As skilled seafarers, the Minoans employed a range of sophisticated vessels. They are often credited with having developed the first “navy,” albeit used for trade rather than war. The Minoans’ impressive trading network gave them influence across the Aegean Sea in the eastern Mediterranean, and far beyond. Minoan artifacts have been found in Egypt, modern Lebanon, Syria, Israel, and Cyprus. Not only were Minoan goods widely transported, but the Minoans themselves also settled in their trading destinations. Murals excavated at Tell el-Dab’a (ancient Avaris) in Egypt

are Minoan in style and feature typical Cretan symbols such as bulls. Minoan-style paintings have also been unearthed at Tel Kabri in Israel.

Palace culture

Minoan life was characterized by highly developed urban settlements dominated by splendid palaces, which were home to Crete’s rulers. The major cities on Crete were Knossos, Phaistos, Mallia, and Zakros, of which Knossos was the most opulent.

The cities, like those of Mesopotamia (see pp.54–55) and other civilizations of the time, were political, religious, administrative, cultural, and trading centers. Kings played both a political and a religious role and many government officials were likely to have been priests.



Natural inspiration

This jar is from the late Minoan period (c. 1450–1400 BCE), when Mycenaean influence was evident. Natural imagery was popular, and octopuses would have been a common sight.